

Topic 7: Superpowers

7.1 What is a Superpower?

Superpower: A nation or group of nations with the ability to project dominating power and influence on a global scale, across military, economic, political, and cultural dimensions. The term was first used during World War II to describe the USA, USSR, and British Empire. Today, the USA is often considered the sole superpower, with China as a rapidly rising challenger.

Emerging power: A nation rapidly increasing its global influence but not yet achieving superpower status. Often characterised by large population, fast economic growth, growing military capability, and increasing geopolitical assertiveness. Examples: China (often now classed as a superpower), India, Brazil, Russia (former superpower, diminished but still significant).

Types of Power

Type	Definition	Examples
Hard power	Coercive power through military force, economic sanctions, or threats	US military interventions (Iraq 2003, Afghanistan 2001–2021); Russian energy supply threats and military invasion of Ukraine (2022); Chinese military build-up in South China Sea; economic sanctions (Western sanctions on Russia, Iranian oil embargo)
Soft power	Influence through attraction, persuasion, culture, values, and diplomacy rather than coercion	Hollywood and American media (Netflix: 260M subscribers globally); US universities (attract 1M+ international students); BBC World Service (492M weekly audience); K-pop (BTS, Blackpink); Chinese Confucius Institutes (500+ worldwide); French cuisine and fashion; Japanese anime/manga

Smart power	Strategic combination of hard and soft power tailored to specific situations	US foreign policy blending military capability with cultural influence, aid, and diplomacy. China's Belt and Road Initiative combines infrastructure investment (hard) with cultural exchange programmes (soft).
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Characteristics of Superpowers

- **Economic dominance** — large GDP (USA: \$27.4 trillion, China: \$17.8 trillion in 2024); dominance of global trade and finance; home to major TNCs; reserve currency status (US dollar: 59% of global foreign exchange reserves); control of international financial institutions.
- **Military power** — large, technologically advanced armed forces; nuclear capability (USA: 5,500 warheads, Russia: 6,257); global force projection through overseas bases (USA: 750+ bases in 80 countries), aircraft carriers (USA: 11, China: 3), and space/cyber capabilities; defence spending (USA: \$886 billion/yr, 39% of world total).
- **Political/diplomatic influence** — permanent seats on UN Security Council (USA, Russia, China, UK, France) with veto power; leadership of alliances (NATO, EU, BRICS); ability to set global agendas; influence over international organisations (IMF, World Bank, WTO).
- **Cultural/ideological influence** — global spread of language (English: 1.5 billion speakers; Mandarin: 1.1 billion), media, values, education systems, consumer brands, and way of life.
- **Demographic weight** — large population provides labour force, military personnel, consumer market, and innovation capacity. China: 1.4 billion; India: 1.44 billion (world's most populous since 2023); USA: 340 million.
- **Resource base** — territorial size, access to natural resources (energy, minerals, food), strategic geographic location (controlling trade routes, choke points).

7.2 Changing Patterns of Power

Historical Superpowers

Era	Dominant Power(s)	Key Characteristics
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16th–17th century	Spain, Portugal	Colonial empires, maritime power, control of American colonies, gold/silver extraction
18th–19th century	British Empire	Largest empire in history (~25% of world land and population), industrial revolution, naval supremacy (Royal Navy), global trade dominance, English language spread, cultural influence
Late 19th century	Multiple European powers	"Scramble for Africa" (1884–1914), imperial competition, industrialisation of Germany, France, and Japan
1945–1991	USA and USSR (bipolar)	Cold War: ideological competition (capitalism vs communism), nuclear arms race, proxy wars (Korea, Vietnam, Afghanistan), space race, NATO vs Warsaw Pact, division of Europe (Iron Curtain)
1991–2010s	USA (unipolar)	Sole superpower after USSR collapse. Military interventions (Gulf War, Kosovo, Iraq, Afghanistan), economic dominance, cultural hegemony, promotion of liberal democracy and free markets
2010s–present	Shifting towards multipolar	USA still dominant but challenged by China's rise. Russia's military reassertion. India's emergence. BRICS expansion. EU as economic bloc. Increasing contestation of US-led order.

The Rise of China

China's transformation from a poor, agrarian economy to the world's second-largest economy is the defining geopolitical shift of the 21st century:

- **Economic growth** — GDP grew from \$306 billion (1980) to \$17.8 trillion (2024), averaging 9.5%/yr for 40 years. 800 million people lifted from extreme poverty (1978–2020). China became the world's largest manufacturer (28% of global manufacturing output), largest exporter, and largest trading partner of 120+ countries.
- **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)** — launched 2013, a \$1+ trillion infrastructure investment programme across 140+ countries in Asia, Africa, Europe, and Latin America. Includes railways, ports, highways, power plants, and digital infrastructure. Creates Chinese economic influence and political goodwill, but criticised for "debt-trap diplomacy" (Sri Lanka's Hambantota Port leased to China for 99 years after Sri Lanka couldn't repay loans) and environmental damage.

- **Military modernisation** — China has the world's largest navy by vessel count (370+), 2 million active military personnel, nuclear capability (~350 warheads), space programme (Tiangong space station), and AI/cyber warfare investment. Military spending: \$292 billion/yr (2nd largest globally). Assertive actions in South China Sea (building artificial islands with military bases).
- **Technology leadership** — Huawei (5G infrastructure), TikTok (1.5 billion users), Alibaba (e-commerce), Tencent (WeChat), DJI (drones), BYD (EVs). China leads in patent applications, scientific publications, and AI research. However, US-China tech competition has led to export controls on advanced semiconductors.
- **Soft power** — Confucius Institutes, international students, media expansion (CGTN, Xinhua), Chinese cuisine, traditional medicine, tourism. However, soft power undermined by authoritarian governance, human rights concerns (Uyghur detention in Xinjiang, Hong Kong crackdown, Tibet), and COVID-19 pandemic response.

Case Study: China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI)

Launched by President Xi Jinping in 2013, the BRI is the largest infrastructure programme in history. **Scale:** \$1+ trillion invested across 140+ countries, ~65% of world population. Projects include: Gwadar Port (Pakistan, \$62 billion China-Pakistan Economic Corridor), Mombasa-Nairobi Railway (Kenya, \$3.6 billion), Jakarta-Bandung High-Speed Railway (Indonesia), power plants across Southeast Asia and Africa. **China's motivations:** secure trade routes for exports and raw material imports, deploy excess industrial capacity (steel, cement), build geopolitical influence, establish yuan as international currency, create new markets for Chinese goods, challenge US-led global order. **Benefits for host countries:** infrastructure development (roads, railways, ports, power) that many countries desperately need but cannot finance domestically; job creation during construction; improved connectivity and trade capacity. **Criticisms:** "debt-trap diplomacy" (countries taking unsustainable Chinese loans, then forced to cede strategic assets — Hambantota Port, Sri Lanka); projects often use Chinese labour and materials rather than local; environmental damage (coal power plants, deforestation for infrastructure); lack of transparency; corruption concerns; some projects are white elephants (underutilised). **Geopolitical significance:** the BRI represents China's bid to reshape the global economic order, creating an alternative to US/Western-dominated institutions. The US, EU, Japan, and India have launched competing initiatives (G7 Partnership for Global Infrastructure and Investment: \$600 billion) but on a smaller scale.

7.3 Global Governance and Institutions

International Governmental Organisations (IGOs)

Organisation	Membership	Role	Criticisms
United Nations (UN)	193 member states	Maintain international peace (Security Council, peacekeeping), promote human rights (UDHR), coordinate development (SDGs), humanitarian aid (UNHCR, UNICEF, WFP)	Security Council veto power allows P5 (USA, Russia, China, UK, France) to block action; lack of enforcement capability; bureaucratic; slow to respond to crises; unrepresentative (no African/South American permanent Security Council seats)
IMF	190 countries	Promotes global monetary stability; provides emergency loans to countries in financial crisis (conditional on "structural adjustment")	Loan conditions (austerity, privatisation, deregulation) can harm poor populations; voting power weighted by economic size (US has effective veto); imposes Western economic models; criticised as serving creditor nations' interests
World Bank	189 countries	Provides development loans and grants; funds infrastructure, education, and health projects in LICs	Large infrastructure focus can cause environmental damage and displacement; conditionality; US dominance in leadership selection; limited effectiveness in reducing poverty in some regions
WTO	164 countries	Promotes free trade; negotiates tariff reductions; settles trade disputes	Favours large, powerful economies; developing countries lack negotiating power; agricultural subsidies in HICs (EU, USA) disadvantage LIC farmers; Doha Round stalled since 2001

NATO	32 countries	Collective defence alliance (Article 5: attack on one is attack on all). Led by the USA.	Seen as US-dominated; expansion eastward (Finland, Sweden joined 2023–24) provoked Russian hostility; some question relevance post-Cold War; burden-sharing disputes (European members criticised for low defence spending)
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Emerging Groupings

- **BRICS** (Brazil, Russia, India, China, South Africa + Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, UAE, Saudi Arabia from 2024) — represents ~46% of world population and ~36% of global GDP (PPP). The New Development Bank (\$100 billion capital) provides an alternative to the World Bank. BRICS challenges Western dominance of global governance but members have very different political systems and interests.
- **G7** (USA, UK, France, Germany, Italy, Canada, Japan + EU) — annual summit of the world's largest advanced economies. Coordinates economic policy, climate action, and security. Criticised as an unrepresentative "rich nations' club."
- **G20** — 19 countries + EU + AU, representing 85% of global GDP. More inclusive than G7 but criticised for informal, non-binding nature.
- **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)** — China, Russia, India, Pakistan, Central Asian states. Security and economic cooperation. Represents ~40% of world population.

7.4 Superpowers, Conflict, and the Environment

Geopolitical Tensions and Conflict

- **US-China rivalry** — the defining geopolitical competition of the 21st century. Contested areas: trade (tariffs, technology restrictions), Taiwan (China claims sovereignty; US pledges to defend), South China Sea (territorial disputes, freedom of navigation), technology (AI, semiconductors, 5G), ideology (liberal democracy vs authoritarian capitalism).
- **Russia-West confrontation** — Russia's invasion of Ukraine (2022) marked the most severe breach of European security since 1945. Consequences: NATO expansion (Finland, Sweden), Western

sanctions, global energy and food price crisis, nuclear escalation risk, reshaping of European security architecture.

- **Middle East tensions** — Iran-Saudi Arabia rivalry, Israel-Palestine conflict, competition for influence between USA, Russia, and China in the region.
- **Resource competition** — control of energy resources (oil, gas, critical minerals) drives geopolitical competition. Arctic sovereignty disputes (Russia, USA, Canada, Denmark/Greenland, Norway) intensifying as ice melt opens new shipping routes and resource access.

Superpowers and the Global Commons

Global commons: Resources and spaces that lie beyond national jurisdiction, shared by all: the atmosphere, the high seas, outer space, and (partially) Antarctica and the deep seabed. Managing the global commons requires international cooperation, but superpower competition often undermines this.

- **Climate change** — addressing climate change requires all major emitters to cooperate (Paris Agreement). But superpowers often prioritise economic growth: China emits 31% of global CO₂; USA: 14%; India: 7%. The US withdrew from Paris Agreement under Trump (rejoined under Biden). Developing countries demand climate finance from historic emitters. COP process is slow and contested.
- **Oceans** — overfishing (34% of fish stocks overfished, FAO), plastic pollution (~11 million tonnes/yr entering oceans), deep-sea mining disputes, South China Sea sovereignty claims. The UN High Seas Treaty (2023) aims to protect biodiversity in international waters.
- **Space** — militarisation of space (anti-satellite weapons tested by USA, Russia, China, India), satellite congestion, space debris, resource extraction on the Moon and asteroids. Outer Space Treaty (1967) prohibits nuclear weapons in space but is increasingly outdated.
- **Arctic** — melting sea ice opens the Northern Sea Route (40% shorter than Suez Canal for Europe-Asia shipping). Five Arctic states (Russia, USA, Canada, Denmark, Norway) and China compete for access to resources (oil, gas, minerals) and trade routes.

Case Study: The USA as a Superpower

The USA has been the world's dominant superpower since 1945 and remains so, though its relative power is declining. **Economic:** \$27.4 trillion GDP (2024, world's largest at market

exchange rates); home to 37% of the world's top 500 companies; US dollar is the global reserve currency (59% of global reserves); Wall Street and Silicon Valley dominate global finance and technology. **Military:** \$886 billion defence budget (39% of world total); 750+ overseas military bases in 80 countries; 11 aircraft carriers; 5,500 nuclear warheads; global intelligence network (CIA, NSA); NATO leadership. **Soft power:** Hollywood (\$42 billion global box office), American music, social media (Facebook, Instagram, X), US universities (8 of world's top 10), English language, NBA, NFL, cultural values of freedom and democracy. **Challenges:** rising national debt (\$34+ trillion), domestic political polarisation, declining trust in institutions, relative economic decline vs China (China's GDP was 12% of US GDP in 2000; now 65%), Afghanistan withdrawal (2021) damaged credibility, growing anti-American sentiment in many regions, domestic inequality (Gini coefficient: 0.39, high for an HIC). **Assessment:** the USA remains the world's most powerful nation across all dimensions of power, but its dominance is no longer unchallenged. The 21st century is increasingly multipolar.

Case Study: India as an Emerging Power

India (population 1.44 billion, world's most populous country since 2023) is the world's fastest-growing major economy and an increasingly significant geopolitical player. **Economic:** \$3.7 trillion GDP (5th largest); growth rate ~7%/yr; large, young workforce (median age 28); growing middle class (400 million); IT services hub (Bangalore, Hyderabad: \$245 billion sector); "Make in India" manufacturing push. **Military:** 1.5 million active troops (4th largest); nuclear power (~170 warheads); growing naval capability (aircraft carrier, nuclear submarines); space programme (Chandrayaan-3 Moon landing 2023, Mangalyaan Mars orbiter 2014). **Diplomatic:** largest democracy; non-aligned tradition (balances relationships with USA, Russia, and China); G20 presidency 2023; growing voice in BRICS, QUAD (with USA, Japan, Australia), and UN reform advocacy. **Soft power:** Bollywood (1,500+ films/yr, largest global audience), yoga, cuisine, diaspora (18 million overseas Indians including 4.8 million in USA). **Challenges:** 228 million people still in extreme poverty; severe air pollution (14 of world's 20 most polluted cities); water stress; infrastructure gaps (roads, electricity); gender inequality; communal tensions; bureaucratic inefficiency. **Assessment:** India has the potential to become a superpower by mid-century (projected 3rd largest economy by 2030), but only if it can address poverty, infrastructure, education, and governance challenges. Its demographic dividend (large young workforce) is an opportunity that could become a liability without adequate job creation.

Exam Tip: Edexcel superpower questions often ask you to evaluate whether global power is becoming more or less multipolar. Structure your answer around evidence FOR multipolarity (China's rise, BRICS expansion, declining US share of global GDP, Russia's military assertiveness, EU as economic bloc) and evidence AGAINST (US military dominance remains unchallenged, dollar hegemony, US tech leadership, no country matches the USA across ALL dimensions of power). Use specific data to support your argument.

Exam Tip: When discussing superpowers and the global commons, always consider the tension between national interest and global cooperation. Climate change requires collective action but each superpower has incentives to free-ride. The Paris Agreement is voluntary precisely because mandatory targets were politically impossible. This tension between sovereignty and collective action is a recurring exam theme.

Exam Tip: Always use the concepts of hard power, soft power, and smart power in your answers. The most sophisticated responses recognise that power is multidimensional: China may have growing economic and military hard power but still lags behind the USA in soft power (cultural appeal, university prestige, media influence). Conversely, Japan has enormous soft power (anime, technology, cuisine) but limited hard power (constitutionally constrained military). These nuances demonstrate genuine understanding.

7.5 BRICS+ and the Emerging Multipolar Order

BRICS: An acronym for the grouping of major emerging economies: Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa. Originally coined by economist Jim O'Neill (Goldman Sachs, 2001) as "BRIC" to describe the four fastest-growing large economies. South Africa joined in 2010. In January 2024, BRICS expanded to BRICS+ by admitting Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, the UAE, and Saudi Arabia. Argentina was invited but declined under new president Milei.

BRICS+ Profile and Significance

Indicator	BRICS+ (2024)	G7
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Member countries	10 (BRICS original + Egypt, Ethiopia, Iran, UAE, Saudi Arabia)	7 (USA, UK, France, Germany, Italy, Canada, Japan) + EU
Share of world population	~46%	~10%
Share of global GDP (PPP)	~36%	~30%
Share of global GDP (market rates)	~28%	~44%
Share of global oil production	~44% (with Saudi Arabia, UAE, Russia)	~20%
Nuclear powers	3 (China, Russia, India)	3 (USA, UK, France)
UN Security Council permanent seats	2 (China, Russia; India/Brazil aspiring)	3 (USA, UK, France)

Strengths and Limitations of BRICS+

- **New Development Bank (NDB):** established 2014, capitalised at \$100 billion. Provides infrastructure and development loans as an alternative to the World Bank, without Western conditionality (no demands for privatisation, austerity, or human rights compliance). Lent \$33 billion by 2023. Headquartered in Shanghai; president has always been from a member state.
- **Currency initiatives:** BRICS nations have discussed creating a common currency or settlement mechanism to reduce dependence on the US dollar. In 2023, 40% of Russia-China trade was settled in yuan. However, a true BRICS currency faces enormous technical and political obstacles — India and China do not trust each other, member currencies have different strengths, and no agreement on who would control monetary policy.
- **Diversification of global governance:** BRICS gives a platform to challenge the US/Western-dominated institutions (IMF, World Bank, WTO, NATO). The 2023 Johannesburg summit communiqué called for reform of the UN Security Council (India and Brazil want permanent seats) and the Bretton Woods institutions.

- **Internal tensions and limitations:** BRICS is not a coherent alliance. China-India border disputes (2017 Doklam standoff, 2020 Galwan Valley clash killing 20 Indian soldiers) create deep distrust. Brazil under Lula is ideologically distant from China under Xi. Russia is internationally isolated since 2022 Ukraine invasion. Saudi Arabia and Iran are historical rivals (though they signed a Chinese-brokered normalisation deal in 2023). Member countries have different currencies, regulatory systems, political ideologies, and geopolitical alignments. BRICS lacks a common military, a treaty framework, or enforcement mechanisms. It is fundamentally a political discussion forum, not an integrated bloc like the EU.
- **Assessment:** BRICS+ is significant as a symbol of "Global South" assertion against Western dominance, and the NDB provides a real alternative financing mechanism. However, its ability to fundamentally challenge the US-led global order is limited by its internal divisions, the continued dominance of the US dollar, and the lack of institutional machinery to translate shared grievances into common action.

7.6 Contested Spaces: South China Sea

Contested space: A geographic area where two or more states or actors claim sovereignty, jurisdiction, or rights, creating conflict and potential flashpoints. Contested spaces include disputed maritime zones, border regions, and global commons areas where national interests collide.

Case Study: The South China Sea — A Contested Space

The South China Sea is one of the world's most strategically significant and contested maritime regions. **Strategic importance:** ~\$5 trillion of trade passes through annually (~30% of global maritime trade); contains significant oil and gas reserves (estimated 11 billion barrels of oil, 190 trillion cubic feet of gas); major fisheries supporting food security for hundreds of millions; strategic military location controlling sea lanes between the Indian and Pacific Oceans. **Claimants:** China claims ~90% of the sea (the "nine-dash line," a historical claim with no legal basis in international law), overlapping with the Exclusive Economic Zones (EEZs) of Vietnam, Philippines, Malaysia, Brunei, and Taiwan. The Spratly Islands, Paracel Islands, and Scarborough Shoal are all disputed. **China's actions:** From 2013, China began an extraordinary programme of artificial island construction, dredging coral reefs to create islands and building military installations (runways, missile batteries, radar systems, hangars for fighter jets) in the Spratly and Paracel Islands. By

2017, China had created ~3,200 acres of new land in the sea. This created "facts on the ground" (or water) that are very difficult to reverse. **International legal ruling:** In 2016, the Permanent Court of Arbitration ruled (in Philippines vs China) that China's nine-dash line claim had no legal basis under UNCLOS (UN Convention on the Law of the Sea). China refused to accept or participate in the ruling, declaring it "null and void." **US response:** The USA (not a claimant but a guarantor of freedom of navigation) conducts regular "Freedom of Navigation Operations" (FONOPs), sailing warships within 12 nautical miles of Chinese-built islands to contest China's sovereignty claims. This has caused dangerous close encounters between US and Chinese warships. **Regional responses:** Vietnam, Philippines, and Malaysia have all issued protests. The Philippines under Marcos Jr. has strengthened its US alliance; Vietnamese fishermen have been harassed by Chinese coast guard vessels. ASEAN as a bloc has been unable to respond coherently because China-aligned members (Cambodia, Laos) block strong communiqués. **Geopolitical significance:** The South China Sea illustrates how a rising power (China) uses incremental, "grey zone" tactics (island building, coast guard harassment rather than outright military attack) to gradually expand its de facto control of a contested space, while the international rules-based order (UNCLOS, arbitration rulings) proves unable to constrain it. It is a microcosm of the broader US-China competition and the challenge of managing multipolar competition in the 21st century.

7.7 Contested Spaces: Outer Space

Case Study: Outer Space — The New Contested Frontier

Outer space was once the exclusive domain of two superpowers (USA and USSR); today it has become a multi-player contested arena with enormous strategic, economic, and scientific stakes.

Current actors: USA (NASA, Space Force, SpaceX, Blue Origin), China (CNSA, Long March rockets, Tiangong space station, Chang'e lunar programme), Russia (Roscosmos, though capabilities declining after Ukraine sanctions), European Space Agency, India (ISRO — first lunar south pole landing, Chandrayaan-3, 2023), Japan (JAXA), UAE (Hope Mars orbiter, 2021), and private companies (SpaceX, Planet Labs, OneWeb). **Militarisation:** All major powers have anti-satellite (ASAT) weapons. China tested a direct-ascent ASAT missile in 2007 (destroying its own weather satellite, creating 3,000+ pieces of tracked debris). Russia tested an ASAT weapon in 2021, which the US called "reckless" and "threatening." The USA, Russia, and China all have space-based intelligence, surveillance, reconnaissance, and GPS jamming capabilities. The USA established Space Force (2019) as a separate military branch; China and Russia have equivalent

military space commands. **Economic stakes:** The global space economy is worth \$546 billion (2022) and growing rapidly. SpaceX's Starlink constellation (6,000+ satellites providing global broadband) is transforming connectivity in remote areas and demonstrated military value in Ukraine (Starlink terminals provided battlefield communications after Russian cyber-attacks on Ukrainian satellite communications). Asteroid mining could theoretically extract trillions of dollars of minerals (one asteroid — 16 Psyche — is estimated to contain iron-nickel worth \$700 quintillion). Lunar helium-3 is theorised as a future fusion fuel. **The Artemis Accords vs China:** The USA-led Artemis programme (returning humans to the Moon by ~2026, with international partners) operates under the "Artemis Accords," a set of principles for sustainable space exploration. China and Russia are not signatories and are developing their own International Lunar Research Station (ILRS). This parallel architecture mirrors Cold War competition. **Legal framework — increasingly inadequate:** The Outer Space Treaty (1967) prohibits nuclear weapons in space and national appropriation of celestial bodies, but was written before commercial space, asteroid mining, or ASAT weapons were relevant concerns. It does not prohibit conventional weapons in space, satellite interference, or private resource extraction. The 1972 Liability Convention addresses damage from space objects but is inadequate for the crowded orbital environment. Space debris is a growing existential threat to the space environment (Kessler Syndrome: a cascade of debris from collisions could make certain orbits unusable). **Geopolitical significance:** Space is increasingly a "fourth domain" of conflict alongside land, sea, and air. Disabling an adversary's satellites (GPS, communications, intelligence) would be devastating in a modern conflict. The growing commercialisation of space by US companies (SpaceX's revenues exceed NASA's budget) gives the USA structural advantages, but China's state-directed investment programme is rapidly closing the gap.

7.8 Arctic Geopolitics

Case Study: The Arctic — Climate Change and Superpower Competition

The Arctic is one of the world's most rapidly changing regions — both physically (warming 4x faster than global average) and geopolitically. **Physical context:** Arctic sea ice extent has declined by ~40% since the 1980s. The Arctic Ocean could be seasonally ice-free by the 2030s–2040s. Permafrost is thawing, releasing methane (a powerful greenhouse gas) and destabilising infrastructure. **Economic significance of an ice-free Arctic:** The Northern Sea Route (NSR, along Russia's Arctic coast) is 40% shorter than the Suez Canal for shipping between Europe and East

Asia. Transit traffic on the NSR grew from 4 ships (2010) to 85 ships (2022). The Arctic holds ~13% of the world's undiscovered oil reserves and 30% of undiscovered natural gas (USGS estimates), plus large deposits of rare earth minerals, gold, and diamonds. **Territorial claims and legal framework:** The Arctic Ocean is governed by UNCLOS, which gives coastal states (Russia, USA/Alaska, Canada, Norway, Denmark/Greenland) 200 nautical mile EEZs and the right to claim extended continental shelves up to 350 nm. The Arctic Council (established 1996: Russia, USA, Canada, Norway, Denmark, Sweden, Finland, Iceland + indigenous peoples) is the primary governance forum, but its work was severely disrupted by Russia's 2022 Ukraine invasion (the other seven members suspended cooperation with Russia). **Russia's Arctic strategy:** Russia has the longest Arctic coastline (~24,000 km) and the most Arctic territory. It has invested heavily in Arctic militarisation: re-opened Cold War military bases (Nagurskoye on Franz Josef Land, Tiksi), deployed Arctic-capable missiles (Bastion, Iskander), developed nuclear-powered icebreakers (the world's largest fleet), and established the Northern Fleet as a military district. Russia sees the Arctic as central to its resource future (oil & gas fields north of the Arctic Circle supply ~20% of Russian GDP) and strategic identity. **China in the Arctic:** China is not an Arctic state but declared itself a "near-Arctic power" (2018). China participates in Arctic Council observer status, has invested in Greenlandic mining, operates Svalbard scientific research facilities (under the 1920 Svalbard Treaty which grants Norway sovereignty but allows all signatories access), and has proposed a "Polar Silk Road" under the BRI. China co-owns an Arctic LNG project with Russia. Western countries view Chinese Arctic ambitions with concern, seeing them as part of broader strategic positioning. **Climate-security nexus:** The Arctic powerfully illustrates how climate change drives geopolitical competition. Melting ice does not just create environmental problems; it opens new resource frontiers and shipping routes that immediately attract superpower competition. The Arctic is simultaneously a site of climate catastrophe (for indigenous communities, wildlife, and global climate systems) and a geopolitical opportunity (for states with Arctic territory or ambitions).

7.9 The USA: Decline or Resilience?

The Decline Thesis

Several scholars and analysts argue that US hegemony is in structural decline:

- **Relative economic decline:** US share of global GDP (market rates) fell from ~40% (1960) to ~26% (2024). China's GDP was 12% of US GDP in 2000; by 2024 it is 65% at market rates and already

larger in PPP terms. The US debt reached \$34+ trillion, with annual interest payments (\$1 trillion) exceeding defence spending.

- **Military setbacks:** the Vietnam War (1975 withdrawal), the 2003 Iraq War (WMD narrative discredited, sectarian conflict unleashed), the 20-year Afghanistan War ending in the chaotic 2021 withdrawal, the inability to deter Russia's invasion of Ukraine, and China's island-building in the South China Sea — all challenge the image of US military omnipotence.
- **Domestic dysfunction:** rising political polarisation (2021 Capitol riot), declining trust in institutions, infrastructure gap (failing roads, bridges, water systems), gun violence (45,000+ deaths/yr), inequality (Gini: 0.39, high for HIC), racial tensions, and opioid crisis. These domestic weaknesses constrain US foreign policy ambition.
- **Soft power erosion:** the US "brand" (liberal democracy, human rights, rule of law) was damaged by Abu Ghraib (torture), Guantanamo Bay, Wikileaks revelations, Edward Snowden NSA surveillance disclosures, and the political chaos of the Trump era. The USA is less effective as a model for democratic governance than in the 1990s.
- **Technology challenge:** China is closing the technology gap. Huawei's 5G infrastructure is technically superior to Western alternatives. China leads in some AI research metrics. Chinese universities are increasingly competitive. US semiconductor export controls represent an admission that China is approaching or matching US capabilities in critical areas.

The Resilience Thesis

Counterarguments suggest US power remains dominant and resilient:

- **Unmatched military:** \$886 billion defence budget (39% of world total); 750+ overseas bases; 11 aircraft carriers (China has 3); most advanced fighter jets (F-35 fleet of 800+, vs China's J-20); global intelligence network; nuclear triad (land, sea, air-based nuclear weapons). No other country can project military force globally at anything approaching US scale.
- **Dollar hegemony:** 59% of global foreign exchange reserves are in US dollars; most international commodity trade (oil, gold) is denominated in dollars; the USA can impose financial sanctions more effectively than any other state because access to the dollar system is essential for global commerce. This "exorbitant privilege" is a structural advantage with no near-term replacement.
- **Technological leadership:** Silicon Valley generates 30%+ of global tech innovation. Apple, Microsoft, Alphabet, Amazon, Meta, and Nvidia are the world's most valuable tech companies. US universities (MIT, Stanford, Caltech, Harvard) dominate global research rankings. The CHIPS Act (\$52 billion, 2022) aims to restore domestic semiconductor production leadership.

- **Alliance network:** NATO (32 members), AUKUS (Australia, UK, USA — nuclear submarine technology sharing, 2021), QUAD (USA, India, Japan, Australia — Indo-Pacific security), US-Japan and US-South Korea bilateral alliances. No other power has comparable alliance architecture. China has essentially no formal military alliances (Russia-China "no limits" partnership is not a formal treaty).
- **Demographic advantage (relative):** the USA has a younger and faster-growing population than China (which faces demographic decline due to one-child policy legacy) or Europe. Immigration continues to attract top global talent to US universities and companies.
- **Adaptation:** the US has reinvented itself multiple times. The 1970s stagflation crisis was followed by Reagan-era growth; the 1991 Soviet collapse reaffirmed US dominance; post-2008 financial crisis, the US tech sector surged. The CHIPS Act, Inflation Reduction Act (clean energy investment), and Infrastructure Investment and Jobs Act represent major public investment not seen since the 1960s.

Exam Tip: The "is the USA declining?" question is a classic Edexcel evaluation task. The most sophisticated answers avoid binary answers. The USA is experiencing **RELATIVE** decline (its share of global GDP, soft power reputation, and military omnipotence are all reduced compared to 1990) but **NOT** absolute decline (it remains the world's most powerful country across all dimensions of power). The key analytical move is to distinguish between the USA's absolute capability (still dominant) and its relative position (being challenged). Also distinguish dimensions: economically China is closing the gap fast; militarily the US remains far ahead; in soft power the US has declined but still leads; demographically the US is stronger than China or Europe.

7.10 India as an Emerging Power — Detailed Analysis

India's Path to Power

Dimension	Current Position	Trajectory	Challenges
Economic size	\$3.7 trillion GDP (5th globally, 2024)	Projected 3rd largest by 2030; ~7% annual growth rate; IT services (\$245bn sector)	228 million still in extreme poverty; informal economy 50%+ of GDP; infrastructure gaps

Demographics	1.44 billion (world's most populous since 2023); median age 28; 600 million under 25	Demographic dividend if jobs created; 1 million entering workforce each month	Demographic dividend can become liability without job creation; social tensions; gender inequality (female labour force participation only 25%)
Military	4th largest military globally; 1.5 million active troops; 170 nuclear warheads; aircraft carrier (INS Vikrant); nuclear submarines	Increasing defence budget; indigenous weapons production ("Make in India Defence"); growing naval presence in Indian Ocean	Border disputes with China (1962 war; 2020 Galwan clash); tensions with Pakistan (nuclear-armed rival); outdated equipment; defence import dependency
Space	Chandrayaan-3 first soft landing on Moon's south pole (2023); Mangalyaan Mars orbiter (2014); Gaganyaan (human spaceflight planned 2025); ISRO launches satellites commercially	Aditya-L1 solar observatory launched 2023; growing commercial launch services; aim to establish space station	Budget smaller than NASA/CNSA; talent drain (brain drain to USA); need to commercialise more effectively
Soft power	Bollywood (1,500+ films/yr; audiences in Africa, Middle East, SE Asia); yoga; cuisine; 18 million diaspora (including 4.8 million in USA, 1.5 million in UK); democracy brand; Sanskrit/Hindu cultural heritage	Growing global profile; G20 presidency 2023 elevated India's leadership credentials; Modi's international travel and bilateral agreements	Treatment of minorities (Muslims, Dalits) undermines democracy brand; media freedom concerns; caste discrimination; Hindu nationalism alienates some diaspora and foreign observers
Geopolitical positioning	Strategic autonomy doctrine (non-alignment tradition); member of BRICS, QUAD,	Increasingly important as US seeks counterweight to China	Balancing act becoming harder: US wants India to distance from Russia (India

G20, SCO; strong ties with USA, Russia, and historically with Global South

in Indo-Pacific ("Pivot to Asia")

buys Russian oil and arms despite Ukraine war); China-India rivalry threatens regional stability

India-China Rivalry

India-China relations are a defining feature of 21st-century Asian geopolitics:

- **Border disputes:** 3,488 km shared border, large sections disputed. 1962 Sino-Indian War ended with Chinese victory and Indian humiliation. The 2020 Galwan Valley clash (Ladakh) killed 20 Indian soldiers and 4 Chinese soldiers in hand-to-hand fighting — the first combat deaths on the border since 1975. India subsequently banned hundreds of Chinese apps (TikTok, WeChat) and restricted Chinese FDI.
- **Economic competition:** India is trying to attract manufacturing investment away from China ("China+1" strategy by companies diversifying supply chains). Apple is expanding production in India (iPhones assembled in Tamil Nadu). India is developing its own tech sector to compete with China.
- **BRI and "string of pearls":** China's BRI investments in South Asian countries (Pakistan, Sri Lanka, Nepal, Bangladesh, Myanmar) encircle India. The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC, \$62 billion) runs through Pakistan-administered Kashmir, which India claims. India refuses to join the BRI; it participates in rival connectivity initiatives (IMEC: India-Middle East-Europe Corridor).
- **Indian Ocean competition:** China has a naval base in Djibouti (Horn of Africa), a port in Hambantota (Sri Lanka), and access to facilities in Pakistan, Myanmar, and Bangladesh. India sees this "string of pearls" as strategic encirclement. India has its own Indian Ocean network of alliances and bases (Andaman & Nicobar Islands military base commanding the Malacca Strait).

7.11 Global Governance Challenges

The Problem of Collective Action

The most critical test of global governance is whether superpowers can cooperate on existential challenges despite their rivalry:

Challenge	What's needed	Current state	Assessment
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Climate change	All major emitters (USA, China, India, EU, Russia) to rapidly reduce emissions. Climate finance from HICs to LICs (\$100bn/yr pledge made in Copenhagen 2009).	Paris Agreement (2015): voluntary nationally determined contributions (NDCs). COP process continues annually. China pledged carbon neutrality by 2060; USA re-joined Paris Agreement (Biden 2021); India pledged 2070 net zero. \$100bn/yr climate finance pledge repeatedly missed; COP28 (2023) launched a loss and damage fund (~\$700 million pledged) but no enforcement mechanism.	Insufficient progress. Current NDCs put world on ~2.5°C trajectory; 1.5°C target essentially out of reach. Geopolitical tensions (US-China rivalry) hamper climate cooperation. G20 accounts for 80% of global emissions.
Nuclear weapons	Arms control agreements to prevent proliferation and reduce stockpiles. Nuclear Non-Proliferation Treaty (NPT) framework.	New START (US-Russia strategic arms limit treaty) suspended by Russia (2023) after Ukraine invasion. USA withdrew from INF Treaty (2019). North Korea has ~40 warheads. Iran close to weapons capability. Pakistan and India not NPT signatories.	Worst period for nuclear arms control since Cold War. Proliferation risks rising. Humanitarian impact discourse (TPAN Treaty on Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons, 2021) has 93 signatories but no nuclear powers.
Pandemic preparedness	Rapid information sharing; equitable vaccine distribution; WHO with authority and resources; surveillance systems in LICs.	COVID-19 exposed failures: WHO starved of funds and politically constrained (China delayed sharing data in early 2020); vaccine nationalism (HICs reserved doses); COVAX underfunded. New Pandemic Treaty being negotiated (2024).	Significant reforms underway but nationalism vs multilateralism tension persists. Pandemic Treaty negotiations stalled over intellectual property (pharmaceutical companies resist compulsory licensing for vaccines).

AI governance	International standards and norms for development, deployment, and military use of artificial intelligence. Prevent AI arms race and autonomous weapons (lethal autonomous weapons systems — LAWS).	UK AI Safety Summit (Bletchley Park, 2023): first international AI safety forum; Bletchley Declaration signed by 28 countries including China and USA. EU AI Act (2024): first comprehensive AI regulation. UN Advisory Body on AI established.	Extremely early stage. China and USA both racing to AI dominance while nominally supporting governance discussions. Risk of LAWS (AI-powered weapons making lethal decisions without human oversight) is a critical gap in international humanitarian law.
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7.12 Exam Essay Framework: Superpowers

Essay Framework: "To what extent is global power becoming more multipolar?" (20 marks)

Introduction — define and contextualise: Define multipolarity (multiple centres of power, no single dominant hegemon) versus unipolarity (one dominant power). State your thesis: global power is becoming more multipolar, driven by China's rise and the broader assertion of emerging powers, but unipolarity has not ended — the USA retains dominance across most dimensions of power.

Paragraph 1 — Evidence FOR multipolarity:

- China's rise: GDP grew from 12% to 65% of US GDP (market rates) between 2000 and 2024; world's largest manufacturer, exporter, trading partner of 120+ countries; BRI influences 140+ countries; military spending \$292bn (2nd globally); nuclear capability; space programme.
- BRICS+ expansion: now represents 46% of world population and 36% of global GDP (PPP); New Development Bank as alternative to World Bank; 2024 expansion signals Global South assertion.
- Russia: despite sanctions and Ukraine war, retains 6,000+ nuclear warheads, has demonstrated willingness to use military force in Europe, and has shown the limits of Western deterrence.

- India: fastest growing major economy; Chandrayaan-3 Moon landing; G20 presidency 2023; growing military capability; strategic autonomy between blocs.
- Regional powers: Turkey asserting independent foreign policy (Nagorno-Karabakh mediator, NATO member buying Russian S-400 missiles); Saudi Arabia diversifying (BRICS membership, normalisation with Iran); EU as regulatory superpower (GDPR affects global tech companies).

Paragraph 2 — Evidence AGAINST full multipolarity (USA still dominant):

- Military: US defence budget (\$886bn) is 3x China's (\$292bn) and 10x Russia's; 11 aircraft carriers vs China's 3; 750+ overseas bases; NATO's 32 members represent combined GDP of \$45 trillion; no country matches US global force projection.
- Dollar hegemony: 59% of global forex reserves in USD; commodity pricing in dollars; financial sanctions power (Iran, Russia, North Korea). De-dollarisation is happening but slowly — no credible alternative exists at scale.
- Technology: Silicon Valley dominates global AI, cloud computing, social media, and semiconductors; top global universities overwhelmingly American; US companies dominate internet infrastructure.
- Soft power: Hollywood, US universities, NBA, English language, democratic values retain enormous global appeal despite recent damage to the US brand.
- Alliance asymmetry: USA has NATO, AUKUS, QUAD; China has no formal military alliances and Russia-China "no limits" partnership is not a treaty.

Paragraph 3 — Nuanced analysis:

- Distinguish dimensions: economically the world is multipolar; militarily still near-unipolar (USA); technologically bipolar (USA and China); culturally still USA-dominated but with reverse flows.
- Distinguish time horizons: short-term (still largely US-led); medium-term (genuine bipolarity likely); long-term (genuinely multipolar if India fulfils potential).
- The "Thucydides Trap" (Graham Allison): historically, a rising power challenging an established power leads to conflict in 12 of 16 historical cases. The US-China relationship is the defining geopolitical risk of the century.

Conclusion — judgement: Global power is becoming more multipolar but has not yet become fully multipolar. The USA remains the world's sole superpower if we apply strict criteria across all dimensions simultaneously — no other country matches US military reach, dollar power, technology leadership, and alliance architecture simultaneously. However, in specific domains

(manufacturing: China; population: India; nuclear parity: Russia; regional hegemony: various) genuine multipolarity exists. The trend is clearly toward greater multipolarity, making the next 20–30 years a period of heightened geopolitical risk as the existing US-led order is contested without yet being replaced.

7.13 Worked Exam Questions

Question 1 (4 marks): Explain the difference between hard power and soft power, using examples.

Model Answer:

Hard power is the ability to influence other states through coercive means — military force, economic sanctions, or threats. The USA's invasion of Iraq (2003) exemplifies military hard power, while Western economic sanctions on Russia following its 2022 invasion of Ukraine illustrate economic hard power. Hard power is direct, visible, and often generates resentment.

Soft power, coined by Joseph Nye (1990), is the ability to attract, persuade, and co-opt other states through cultural appeal, values, institutions, and diplomacy rather than coercion. The USA's Hollywood films, universities, and democratic values project soft power globally; South Korea's K-pop and Netflix dramas exercise soft power across Asia and beyond. Soft power is indirect, operates through attraction rather than compulsion, and tends to generate goodwill rather than resentment. The most effective states exercise "smart power" — a strategic combination of both — as the USA does through combining military alliances (NATO) with cultural exports and educational exchanges.

Question 2 (8 marks): Assess the extent to which China's Belt and Road Initiative benefits developing countries.

Model Answer Framework:

Introduction: The BRI, launched 2013, is the largest infrastructure investment programme in history, with \$1+ trillion invested across 140+ countries. Its impacts on developing countries are genuinely mixed — significant infrastructure benefits exist alongside serious concerns about sovereignty, debt, and development quality.

Benefits: Infrastructure provision that developing countries cannot self-finance — the Mombasa-Nairobi Standard Gauge Railway (Kenya, \$3.6 billion) reduced a journey from 12 hours to 4 hours and cut freight costs. The Gwadar Port (Pakistan) creates deep-water export infrastructure for a landlocked region. Power plants in sub-Saharan Africa provide electricity access. Chinese financing offers fewer conditions than IMF/World Bank loans (no demands for austerity or governance reforms), which many developing country governments prefer. The NDB provides a genuine alternative financing mechanism.

Limitations and criticisms: "Debt-trap diplomacy" — Sri Lanka leased Hambantota Port to China for 99 years (2017) after being unable to repay Chinese loans; Zambia's electricity grid assets were reportedly discussed as collateral. Projects often use Chinese labour and materials (60-80% Chinese contractors in some cases), limiting local employment and technology transfer. Some projects are "white elephants" — the SGR in Kenya is operating at a loss and cannot repay its Chinese loan. Environmental damage (coal power plants, deforestation). Lack of transparency; some loan terms secret from host country parliaments. Corruption in project procurement documented in multiple countries.

Balanced conclusion: The BRI provides real infrastructure benefits that developing countries need, but its design reflects Chinese geopolitical and commercial interests as much as development goals. Benefits are real but uneven; risks of debt dependency and limited local development impact are genuine. The key variable is governance quality in host countries — strong governments can negotiate better terms and capture more benefit; weak, corrupt governments are more vulnerable to exploitative terms.

7.14 Key Data for Exam Use

Indicator	Key Data (approx. 2024)
US GDP	\$27.4 trillion (world's largest at market rates)
China GDP	\$17.8 trillion (2nd globally); larger than USA in PPP terms
India GDP	\$3.7 trillion (5th globally); projected 3rd by 2030
US defence spending	\$886 billion/yr (39% of global total)

China defence spending	\$292 billion/yr (2nd globally)
US nuclear warheads	5,500 (2nd after Russia)
Russia nuclear warheads	6,257 (world's largest arsenal)
US overseas military bases	750+ in 80 countries
US aircraft carriers	11 (China: 3; UK/France: 1 each)
BRI investment	\$1+ trillion across 140+ countries
BRICS+ population share	~46% of world population
BRICS+ GDP (PPP) share	~36%
China manufacturing share	28% of global manufacturing output
China poverty reduction	800 million lifted from extreme poverty 1978–2020
Dollar share of forex reserves	59% (Euro: 20%; Yen: 5%; Yuan: 2.3%)
South China Sea trade value	~\$5 trillion passes through annually
Space economy value	\$546 billion (2022)
Starlink satellites	6,000+ (SpaceX)
China patents filed	World's largest filer of international patents since 2019
NATO members	32 countries (Finland joined 2023, Sweden 2024)
China-India 2020 Galwan clash	20 Indian soldiers killed — first deaths on border since 1975
India population	1.44 billion (world's most populous since 2023)
India IT sector	\$245 billion revenues; 5.4 million employed
Arctic sea ice decline	~40% reduction since 1980s; warming 4x global average

Northern Sea Route — shortcut	40% shorter than Suez Canal for Europe-Asia shipping
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7.15 Superpower Influence on Development

Aid, Trade, and Investment as Tools of Power

Superpowers use economic relationships — aid, trade agreements, investment, and debt — as instruments of geopolitical influence. Understanding this is essential for Edexcel's "superpowers and development" element.

The Washington Consensus vs Beijing Consensus

The **Washington Consensus** refers to the set of economic policies promoted by the IMF, World Bank, and US Treasury for developing countries since the 1980s: fiscal austerity (reducing government deficits), privatisation (selling state enterprises), trade liberalisation (reducing tariffs), deregulation, and market exchange rates. These conditions attached to IMF loans were often deeply unpopular and had mixed results: successful in stabilising economies (Mexico, Turkey, South Korea) but criticised for increasing inequality, cutting social services, and imposing Western economic models on diverse contexts. The 1997 Asian Financial Crisis (when IMF conditions worsened the crisis in Indonesia, Thailand, and South Korea) severely damaged the Washington Consensus's credibility.

The **Beijing Consensus** (coined by Joshua Cooper Ramo, 2004) describes China's alternative development model: state-directed capitalism, pragmatic gradualism (gradual reform rather than "shock therapy"), emphasis on political stability and sovereignty, and non-interference in internal affairs. China offers infrastructure loans (through BRI and NDB) without demanding political or governance reforms. This model appeals to many developing country governments who resent Western conditionality. However, the Beijing Consensus is also criticised for: enabling authoritarian regimes to avoid accountability; using debt to extract strategic concessions (Hambantota); and prioritising Chinese economic interests over genuine development.

Feature	Washington Consensus (IMF/World Bank)	Beijing Consensus (China/BRI)
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Conditions attached	Austerity, privatisation, trade liberalisation, governance reform, human rights	Non-interference; no political conditions; sovereignty respected
Focus	Macroeconomic stability, free markets	Infrastructure investment, industrial development
Currency	USD-denominated loans	Often yuan-denominated; promotes de-dollarisation
Transparency	Public reporting; multilateral governance	Loan terms often secret; bilateral agreements
Outcome in practice	Mixed; effective in some cases; increased inequality in others; 1997 Asian crisis failure	Real infrastructure built; but debt crises in some countries (Sri Lanka, Zambia, Laos)
Geopolitical effect	Extends US/Western economic influence and model globally	Extends Chinese diplomatic and economic influence; challenges US-led order

The Role of TNCs and Superpowers in Africa

Africa has become a major arena of superpower competition in the 21st century. The continent has enormous resources (60% of world's uncultivated arable land, 30% of world's mineral reserves, 12% of world's oil), a rapidly growing population (projected 2.5 billion by 2050), and growing consumer markets.

- China in Africa:** China-Africa trade reached \$282 billion (2022), making China Africa's largest trading partner. Chinese FDI stock in Africa: ~\$40–45 billion (annual flows only ~\$2–5 billion). BRI projects across 40+ African countries (railways, ports, power plants, roads). Criticisms: extractive model (Chinese companies often import Chinese workers and export raw materials); debt sustainability concerns; some projects serve Chinese strategic interests (Djibouti military base; Mombasa-Nairobi railway primarily serves export of Kenyan commodities to China); limited technology transfer.
- USA in Africa:** AGOA (African Growth and Opportunity Act, 2000): gives duty-free access to US markets for 39 sub-Saharan African countries. PEPFAR (President's Emergency Plan for AIDS Relief,

2003): \$100 billion invested in HIV/AIDS treatment, saving ~21 million lives. Prosper Africa initiative and Partnership for Global Infrastructure (as BRI alternative). US AFRICOM (military command) coordinates security partnerships and counter-terrorism operations across the continent (including drone bases in Niger and Djibouti).

- **New actors:** Russia (Wagner Group mercenary operations in Mali, Central African Republic, Sudan; arms sales; disinformation campaigns against French and Western presence in the Sahel); Turkey (drones, military bases in Somalia, Libya, Senegal); UAE and Gulf states (port investments, food security land deals); India (ITEC training programmes, pharmaceutical exports, South-South development cooperation).

Africa's growing importance and the competition among external powers illustrates that the emerging multipolar world is not simply a US-China contest but a complex multi-actor competition in which African states increasingly exercise agency — playing different powers against each other to maximise their own interests.

7.16 Superpower Responsibilities and Global Governance

The "Responsibility to Protect" (R2P) Doctrine

R2P (adopted at the UN World Summit, 2005) holds that states have a responsibility to protect their populations from genocide, war crimes, ethnic cleansing, and crimes against humanity. If a state fails to protect its people (or itself perpetrates atrocities), the international community — including through military intervention — has a responsibility to act.

In practice, R2P has been inconsistently applied:

- Invoked to justify intervention in Libya (2011): NATO air campaign helped overthrow Gaddafi but left Libya as a failed state, discrediting R2P for Russia and China who felt it was used as cover for regime change.
- Not invoked to prevent Syria (300,000+ deaths 2011–2023): Russian and Chinese vetoes in the Security Council blocked action.
- Not effectively applied to Rohingya genocide in Myanmar (2016–2017): 700,000 driven into Bangladesh; China and Russia blocked Security Council action.
- Russia invoked a twisted version of R2P to justify its 2022 invasion of Ukraine (claiming to "protect" Russian-speakers) — widely condemned as cynical misuse of the doctrine.

R2P illustrates the fundamental tension in global governance between sovereignty (a state's right to non-interference) and universalism (universal human rights that supersede sovereignty). Superpowers with Security Council vetoes can block humanitarian intervention when their interests are engaged, exposing the limits of multilateral governance.

Exam Tip: For 20-mark essays on superpowers, the best responses structure around a clear, contestable thesis and use the full range of evidence. A strong essay on "How far are superpowers able to manage global challenges?" would: (1) define global challenges (climate, pandemics, nuclear proliferation, AI, ocean governance); (2) give examples of successful cooperation (Montreal Protocol on ozone, PEPFAR on HIV/AIDS, Paris Agreement); (3) give examples of failure (Ukraine war, Syria, South China Sea, climate finance shortfalls); (4) explain WHY management is difficult (national interests, Security Council veto, free-riding, sovereignty vs collective action); (5) reach a nuanced judgement: superpowers CAN cooperate on global challenges when national interests align (or are not threatened), but fail when cooperation requires sacrificing sovereignty, domestic economic interests, or geopolitical advantage. Quote specific treaties, organisations, and data throughout.